‘Oh, all right, then.’

With that we started chatting away, as you tend to do. It was the beginning of a beautiful friendship. The extent of the chance became clear in a Heathrow hotel during a twelve-hour stopover. I was flicking through Ceefax (ask your dad, kids,) got to page 340 , the cricket page, and saw the headline ‘Trescothick Flies Home’.

Up until that point, I couldn’t really see a way in to a top six of Tres, Vaughan, Bell, Collingwood, Strauss and KP. I turned to Alice, who had popped over from uni, and said ‘Oh, God. There’s an outside chance of me playing here.’ A twelve-hour stopover in Mumbai and two training sessions later, I was in.

Freddie Flintoff became captain when Vaughan finally lost the battle of his wounded knee. In what felt like a dream sequence, he saw me bat and announced: ‘He’s playing.’ This wasn’t great news for Matt Prior, who, as reserve wicketkeeper, was the only other realistic option for a place. Logic dictated that my status, as a specialist opener, gave me priority.

Wow. Here was Freddie, the big hitter, the hero who scared Australia, telling everyone I was his man. We would play together for three years before retirement from international cricket in 2010, following a year-long rehabilitation from knee surgery, broadened his horizons. Not for the last time, it felt as though I was turning the pages of a comic book, wondering what plot twist would next ambush the superhero. Life was not dull.

In this case the superhero clashed, rather predictably, with KP. It is rare for either of two alpha males to defer to the other, but if Freddie liked you, he stood by your side. He was a force of nature, a talismanic figure who loved laughing at his own jokes and drove himself to be a magnificent bowler by developing that elusive skill of hitting the back of a length quickly.

I look at him now, applying that natural determination to a hugely successful secondary career, and wonder whether he could have got more out of himself as a cricketer. He’s a gym bunny, hasn’t had a drink for something like four years, and is ripped to shreds, physically. He’s ten kilos lighter than when he was a player.

That additional mass is the equivalent, for a bowler, of having forty kilos going through your knee and ankle. How much wear and tear would he have avoided had he maintained a slightly lower fighting weight? We’ll